Key question
How was Operation Defensive Shield carried out?

Key date
Operation Defensive Shield: 2002

Operation Defensive Shield, March 2002

In February 2001 Ariel Sharon was elected Prime Minister of Israel. He promised to maintain Israeli sovereignty over Jerusalem and to increase the number of settlements on the West Bank. Meanwhile, the death toll in the Middle East mounted. Hamas and other militant Palestinian groups carried out bombings both inside Israel and also against Israeli troops and settlers in the occupied territories. In March 2002, after 29 Israelis were killed in a Hamas suicide bombing, Sharon launched 'Operation Defensive Shield'.

In order to root out the 'terrorists', Israeli troops and tanks carried out raids inside Palestinian towns and refugee camps on the West Bank and Gaza. They attacked and surrounded Arafat's headquarters in the West Bank town of Ramallah. They also embarked on a policy of targeted assassinations, often using helicopter gunships in order to kill Palestinian militants in their homes or offices. They even used fighter planes to bomb their targets; not surprisingly, women and children, often family members, were also killed. Schools and hospitals were sometimes hit. These buildings may have contained Hamas members but then organisations like Hamas also ran schools and hospitals as well as carrying out military activities. Life in the occupied territories became worse and worse. Fresh water and food became more scarce and very few people had paid work.

Key question
What was the purpose of the security barrier?

Israel's security barrier

By May 2003, over 2000 Palestinians and 760 Israelis had been killed since the *Intifada* started in 2000. This was a far higher number than in the first *Intifada*. In this second *Intifada*, many



Israel's security barrier.